

Passages - Philosophical Essays

In whatever manner God might have created the world, it would always have been regular and in accordance with a certain general order. But God has chosen the most perfect world, that is, the one which is at the same time the simplest in hypotheses and the richest in phenomena, as might be a line in geometry whose construction is easy and whose properties and efforts are extremely remarkable and widespread.

Since the ultimate ground must be in something which is of metaphysical necessity, and since the reason for an existing thing must come from something that actually exists, it follows that there must exist some one entity of metaphysical necessity, that is, there must be an entity whose essence is existence, and therefore something must exist which differs from the plurality of things, which differs from the world, which we have granted and shown is not of metaphysical necessity.

Indifference arises from ignorance, and the wiser one is, the more one is determined to do that which is most perfect.

Pleasure does not derive from uniformity, for uniformity brings forth disgust and makes us dull, not happy: this very principle is a law of delight.

The simplicity of substance does not prevent a multiplicity of modifications, which must be found together in this same simple substance, and which must consist in the variety of its relations to external

things.

But true reasoning depends on necessary or eternal truths, such as those of logic, numbers, and geometry, which bring about an indubitable connection of ideas and infallible consequences. Animals in which these consequences are not noticed are called beasts; but those who know these necessary truths are those that are properly called rational animals, and their souls are called minds

For everything is ordered in things once and for all, with as much order and agreement as possible, since supreme wisdom and goodness can only act with perfect harmony: the present is pregnant with the future; the future can be read in the past; the distant is expressed in the proximate. One could know the beauty of the universe in each soul, if one could unfold all its folds, which only open perceptibly with time. But since each distinct perception of the soul includes an infinity of confused perceptions which embrace the whole universe, the soul itself knows the things it perceives only so far as it has distinct and heightened [revelées] perceptions; and it has perfection to the extent that it has distinct perceptions.

It is true that supreme felicity (with whatever beatific vision or knowledge of God it may be accompanied) can never be complete, because, since God is infinite, he can never be entirely known.

Thus our happiness will never consist, and must never consist, in complete joy, in which nothing is left to desire, and which would dull our mind, but must consist in a perpetual progress to new pleasures and new perfections.

The knowledge of eternal and necessary truths is what distinguishes us from simple animals and furnishes us with reason and the sciences, by raising us to a knowledge of ourselves and of God. And that is what we call the rational soul, or mind, in ourselves.

Complete indifference is required for freedom, then there is scarcely ever a free act [actus], since I think that the case in which everything on both sides is equal scarcely ever comes up. For even if, by chance, the reasons are equal, the passions will not be, and why should we argue about circumstances that do not arise? Nor do I think that one can produce an instance in which it is the will [voluntas] that chooses, since there is [always] some reason for choosing one of two things.